PRODUCT TEARDOWN | NYKAA

Nykaa: shoppers finish the decision outside the app

A teardown of one lip balm purchase, three user conversations and three bets to keep the decision on Nykaa.

3 of 4

shoppers I observed checked options outside Nykaa before deciding

Me plus 2 of 3 users. n = 4, so directional, not statistical.

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The question: what stops a shopper deciding on Nykaa?

1 My own journey

Goal: buy a lip balm.

Criteria: balm or stick, dermatologically tested, vegan, comfortable ingredients, good ratings.

Started from 575+ products and tracked each step as smooth, confusing or slow.

2 Three conversations

User 1: 27, Hubli.

User 2: 25, Chennai, using Nykaa for over a year.

User 3: 27, Chennai.

Open questions on why Nykaa, likes, dislikes and drop-offs, with follow-ups when an answer was unclear.

3 How I read the evidence

Only what I observed or what a user said.

Counts show who raised a point, out of four people.

Limits: one category, one product type, four people, no analytics data.

THE SHOPPER I AM DESIGNING FOR

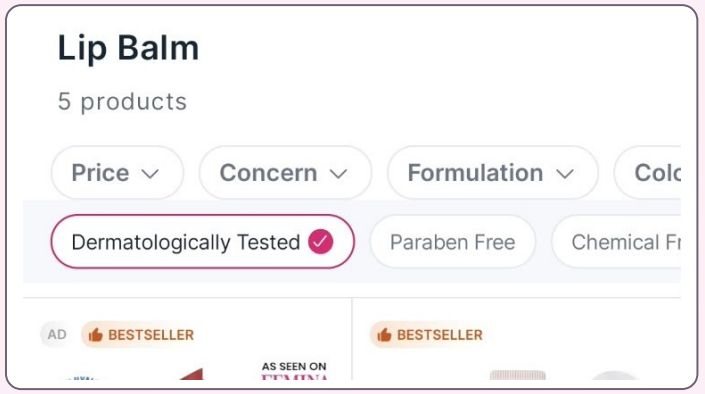
Ingredient- and price-aware beauty shoppers who research before they buy.

Seen in my own criteria (dermatologically tested, vegan, ingredients), User 2 (ingredient and brand comparison) and User 3 (price tracking in the cart).

Six steps from 575 lip balms to the cart

STEP	WHAT I WAS TRYING TO DO	WHAT HAPPENED	FELT
Browse	Find a lip balm	575+ products. Shop by Formulation and Shop by Color gave two clear ways in.	Smooth
Filter	Narrow by format, then by what I care about	Balm and Stick cut 575+ to 456+. Dermatologically Tested left only 4 (5 on a later check), and one product I know belongs there was missing.	Confusing
Shortlist	Pick a brand that fits my criteria	Ratings, offers and Most Reordered helped. Comparing brands meant opening each page one by one.	Slow
Shade	Choose a shade	The swatch looked different online, and no photo showed my shade being worn.	Confusing
Price check	Check the price against my budget	Higher than usual. A brand I know was missing from the filter but appeared in search.	Confusing
Cart	Lock in a safe first purchase	Added the affordable, dermatologically tested, clean option to buy first, and the first pick for later.	Smooth

Proof builds confidence, faith loses it



Filters

Useful, not yet trustworthy

WHAT I SAW

Dermatologically Tested showed 4 products (5 on a later check), yet a product I know qualifies appeared only through search.

MY OPINION

A filter promises a complete list. One miss makes every result set feel incomplete, so I double-checked elsewhere.



Shade preview

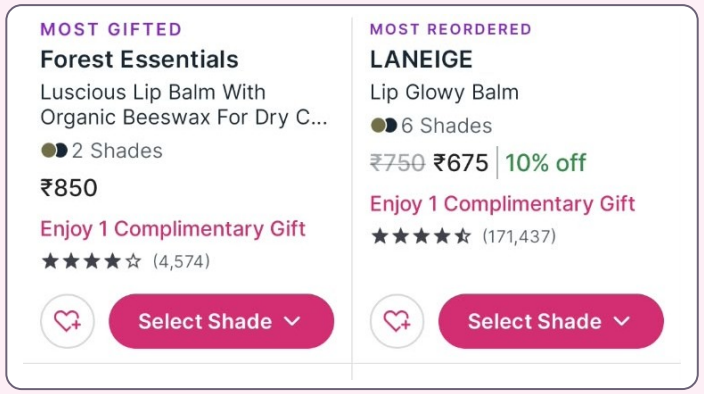
Helps, but not enough

WHAT I SAW

Arm swatches on three skin tones help, but only one shade was shown worn, and not mine. The swatch also looked different online.

MY OPINION

Shade is the riskiest choice on a lip product. This is the moment I left the app to look for visual proof.



Offers and Most Reordered

Works

WHAT I SAW

Listings carry Most Reordered tags, rating counts and offers, which together made a product feel like a safe pick.

MY OPINION

Most Reordered works because it shows people came back. Behavior is stronger proof than a star rating.

What three shoppers told me

User 1

27 | Hubli

LIKES

Easy interface, useful filters, banners that help her pick.

FRICTION

Unannounced delivery calls she cannot always take at the office, and orders returned then re-attempted. Brands she wants are sometimes not listed.

FOLLOW-UP

I asked if she could wishlist the brand. She cannot: if it is not listed, there is nothing to wishlist.

User 2

25 | Chennai | Nykaa for over a year

LIKES

Best Sellers, filters, finding products by ingredient and shade, good offers, smooth buying, fast delivery.

BEHAVIOR

Shortlists a few brands, then uses ChatGPT to compare them. At first she thought Nykaa was mainly for clothing.

FRICTION

One or two dermatologist-recommended brands were not listed.

User 3

27 | Chennai

LIKES

Direct sourcing from brands gives her confidence. Ordering is easy.

BEHAVIOR

Adds several brands to the cart to compare prices, waits for salary, uses ChatGPT to compare.

FRICTION

Prices change while items sit in the cart, checkout sometimes lags, tracking links open third-party sites, and support is mostly a chatbot.

Leaving to verify is the most repeated behavior

THEME	ME	USER 1	USER 2	USER 3	RAISED BY
Checked or compared options outside Nykaa	●		●	●	3 of 4
Trust signals helped (Most Reordered, ratings, offers, direct sourcing)	●		●	●	3 of 4
Preferred brand not listed		●	●		2 of 4
Post-purchase friction (delivery calls, tracking links)		●		●	2 of 4
Filter results felt incomplete	●				1 of 4
Shade preview was not enough	●				1 of 4
Checkout lag, left and returned later				●	1 of 4
Support hard to reach				●	1 of 4

n = 4: me plus three users. Counts show who raised a point, not how often it happens on Nykaa. Green marks a positive signal, pink marks friction.

One root cause, ranked by what it costs Nykaa

SYMPTOM

Shoppers finish the decision on ChatGPT, search and other sites.

WHY?

Nykaa gives data but not answers: is this list complete, which one fits me, will this shade suit me?

WHY?

Three gaps: filters that can omit products, shade previews that cover too little, and no side-by-side comparison.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Ingredient- and price-aware shoppers need to pick a lip balm and shade with confidence inside Nykaa, because filters can omit products, shade previews cover too little and comparing means opening each page.

Now	**Filter completeness**	Hides sellable products without telling the shopper. Verified first-hand.
Next	**Shade confidence**	Highest-stakes choice on a lip product. Verified first-hand.
Next	**In-app comparison**	3 of 4 compared outside Nykaa, two of them using ChatGPT.
Later	**Delivery updates and tracking**	2 of 3 users, two different problems. Needs more users before building.
Later	**Brand not listed**	2 of 3 users. A supply-side call, not a UI fix.
Check first	**Checkout lag**	1 user. Read checkout performance data before judging.

Three bets that keep the decision on Nykaa

1 Now

Make filters complete and honest

FIXES

Filters that omit products, verified first-hand.

IDEA

A routine check that every product with a claim like dermatologically tested appears under that filter. When search finds products your filters exclude, say so: "3 more match your search".

TRADE-OFF

Claims need brand proof before tagging, so the check flags gaps and brand teams confirm them.

2 Next

Show every shade worn on lips

FIXES

Shade doubt that sends shoppers online for swatches.

IDEA

Show each shade on lips across skin tones, starting with top sellers. Some pages already carry arm swatches, and Nykaa announced AI try-on in 2021, starting with L'Oréal products, so the work is coverage.

TRADE-OFF

Photo shoots, brand cooperation and try-on licensing cost money, so start with the top-selling lip shades.

3 Next

Compare shortlisted products side by side

FIXES

Opening each page one by one, and the trips to ChatGPT.

IDEA

Pick up to three products from filter results or the wishlist and see price, key ingredients, claims, rating and shade count in one table.

TRADE-OFF

Shows price gaps to cheaper brands, which can squeeze margin, but it keeps comparison inside Nykaa.

Source: Business Today, 14 Dec 2021, "Nykaa launches AI-backed virtual try-on tech ModiFace" (businesstoday.in).

How I would test each bet before building

BET	CHEAPEST TEST	SUCCESS METRIC	STOP RULE
Filters	Check 50 products that brands list as dermatologically tested against the filter and count how many are missing.	Share of qualifying products that appear under the filter. Target 100%. Guardrail: zero wrongly tagged products.	**Drop it if fewer than 1 in 20 are missing.**
Shades	Add worn-shade photos to the top 10 lip products and run them against unchanged pages for two weeks.	Add-to-cart to order conversion on those products. Guardrail: shade-related returns do not rise.	**Stop if conversion is flat or the lift is under 5% relative.**
Compare	Painted door: a Compare button on filtered results that opens a waitlist screen, with nothing built behind it.	Tap rate on Compare among shoppers who viewed 2+ products. Guardrail: no drop in add-to-cart.	**Do not build if fewer than 2% tap it.**

NOT NOW, AND WHY

Brand not listed. 2 of 3 users, but it is a supply-side call. Later: test a request-a-brand waitlist.

Delivery and tracking. 2 users, two different problems. Talk to more shoppers first.

Checkout lag. 1 user. Read performance data before drawing conclusions.

What changed in how I look at an app

What I usually overlook

I do not use Nykaa often, so I rarely notice each stage. Tracing filters, product details, shade previews and the cues that moved my decision showed how many small steps sit between interest and purchase.

What changed after talking to users

Experience can differ by shopper and perhaps by category or product. Value for money and direct sourcing from brands turned out to matter for trust, which I had not weighed.

What was hardest

Observing each step carefully and writing it down took the most time. Coming back after a break helped me notice insights I had missed.

Biggest learning: a good overall experience can still hide real friction, and follow-up questions show what sits behind a first answer.

NEXT

1) Run the filter check on other filters, such as Vegan, and other categories. 2) Interview five more shoppers, including some who left without buying. 3) Review checkout performance data.